Fifteen times the EU average?

An IMF staff statement, tested against Eurostat and World Bank data

THE CLAIM

> ***“With a population density fifteen times greater than the EU average …”***

International Monetary Fund staff, Country Report 26/29, February 2026

Overview of the 2025 Article IV staff report on Malta.

The density ratio and the report’s population table were checked; the link to strain on services was not.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Ratio is 16.6 on 2024 data; fifteen is slightly low.

SUPPORTED | **LARGELY SUPPORTED** | NOT SUBSTANTIATED | MISLEADING | CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

16.6×

Malta ÷ EU-27, 2024

1,817 people per km² against 110 (Eurostat). The ratio passed 15 in 2021.

13.9–17.2×

Depends on the “average”

Unweighted mean of other states: 13.9. Median: 17.2. EU excluding Malta: 17.0.

−2%

IMF population vs Eurostat

2024 and 2025 values sit about 2% below Eurostat’s 1 January figures.

3.4×

Malta vs the next EU state

World Bank, land area: Malta 1,805, Netherlands 534.

FAIR TO SAY

The sentence also says density strains infrastructure, housing and services. That is a judgement, and this check does not rate it.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

- ☐ IMF: the year and definition behind “fifteen times”.
- ☐ IMF: the basis of its 2024–2027 population values.